

56% would help. 31% don't know how.

National Recovery Month, and three things you can actually do before the month ends.

WHY THIS ISN'T AWARENESS CONTENT

Most of what lands in your inbox this month will be a ribbon, a statistic, and an encouragement to start the conversation. This is not that. The three things below require no budget, no vendor, and no meeting.

56% / 31%

More than half of Americans would help a colleague who was struggling with substance use. Nearly a third simply don't know what to do.

Addiction Policy Forum & Gallup, May 2026

That gap is the whole problem, and it isn't indifference. It's the absence of a script.

Meanwhile **1 in 10 employees** is living with an untreated substance use disorder, and **4 in 5 of the people affected are never treated** — not because treatment doesn't exist, but because the path to it runs straight through the thing people fear most, which is being seen.

All three actions below aim at the same target. Lower the cost of being seen.

1 COST — ONE EMAIL

Fix the bar before you fix the policy

If the alcohol is at a staffed bar and the alternative is a warm can of soda on a side table, you've already told the room which choice is the real one.

Stock two or three genuinely good non-alcoholic options. Same bar, same menu, same eye level. Ask the bartender to offer them first rather than as a consolation, and print them on the list with real names.

Nobody discloses anything. Nobody opts out of anything. The signal isn't the drink — it's that somebody thought about it in advance.

This week: find whoever is planning your next company event and send them this paragraph.

2 COST — ONE INTRANET EDIT

Make help findable without a conversation

Thirty percent of Americans don't know where to find accurate information about substance use disorder, and the people most likely to need it are the least likely to walk into HR and ask.

So put it where it can be found silently. The SAMHSA National Helpline (1-800-662-HELP), [findtreatment.gov](https://www.findtreatment.gov), and 988 for crisis. Add all three to the intranet homepage, the benefits portal landing page, and the back of the break room door — the same places you post the fire exits.

No form, no disclosure, no manager in the loop.

This week: one intranet edit and one printed sign.

3 COST — FIFTEEN MINUTES

Give your managers one sentence

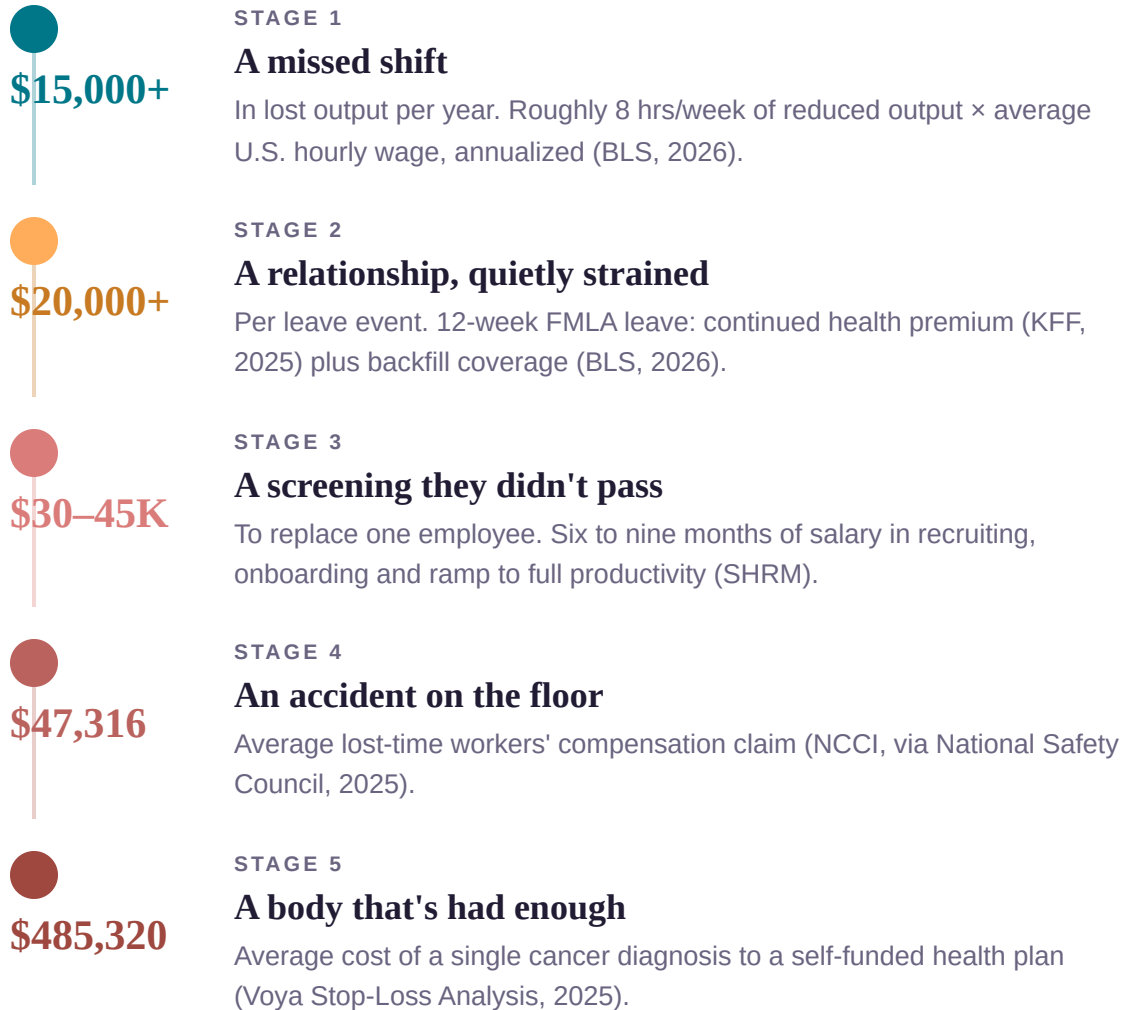
The people who don't know what to do are mostly your people leaders. They notice something, they worry about saying the wrong thing, and so they say nothing until it becomes a performance conversation or an incident.

"I've noticed [specific, observable, work-related thing]. I'm not asking you to explain anything to me. I want to make sure you know what's available, and that using it won't cost you your job."

Three rules underneath it: describe behavior, never diagnose. Don't speculate about cause. Don't promise confidentiality you can't deliver.

This week: fifteen minutes on an agenda that already exists.

Every one of those three actions aims at the left end of this chain.



Someone just had to catch stage one.

Read it right to left and it's a cost problem. Read it left to right and it's a person having a hard year that nobody asked about.

Employee benefits

The EAP is not the answer here, and your clients likely suspect it. At the next renewal ask what EAP utilization was last year for any reason. Then ask what share of it was substance-related. The silence after the second question is the conversation worth having.

Risk and safety

Substance use is tied to 65% of on-the-job accidents, and 10–20% of workplace fatalities involve alcohol or drugs. Heavy drinkers are 30% more likely to file a workers' comp claim. Your clients already pay for this — as incidents rather than as a program.

For both: the highest-leverage thing you can do this month is read a client's drug and alcohol policy the way an employee would read it. Most describe consequences in detail and support in a single line, or not at all. Adding one sentence about voluntarily seeking help — before an incident, without penalty — costs nothing and changes what the entire document communicates.

Sources: Addiction Policy Forum & Gallup, *Addiction Stigma in America*, May 2026 · SAMHSA NSDUH · NSC/NORC Substance Use Cost Calculator · NCADD · U.S. Department of Labor · RAND Corporation · BLS 2026 · KFF 2025 · SHRM · NCCI via National Safety Council 2025 · Voya Stop-Loss Analysis 2025.

Most people reading this are not at the finish line

Recovery Month tends to celebrate the people who made it all the way through, and that is worth doing. But most of the people reading this are somewhere else entirely — cutting back, wondering, worrying about someone at home, or three weeks into something they haven't told anyone about.

Sobriety is personal. Whatever that looks like — total sobriety, recovery, sober curious, cutting back, or supporting someone you love — the work of a recovery-friendly workplace is making sure none of it has to be a secret.

Three things. One month. No budget.

Jess Ferretti · VP of Sales, Sobrynth

If you want to talk about what comes after these three, my calendar is open. And if you advise employers, forward this to three clients — the three things work whether or not we ever speak.

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